simultaneity with the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar*, acting as the other half of the dyadic declaration of the Shansabanis' final triumph over the Ghaznavids and the Oghüz, and the possession of the former's imperial centers (see Chapter 4). But rather than memorializing a Shansabani triumph that essentially acknowledged Ghiyath al-Din's seniority as at Firuzkuh, the Bust arch appeared to focus on the newly crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din. Given the far-reaching ramifications of this fateful victory, it is more than likely that some type of memorialization of it was also erected at their enemies' old capital of Ghazna but has since been lost.

Furthermore, as was the case with the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar* – discussed in Chapters 3 and 4 – the Bust arch's surviving epigraphy also stands out for the uncommonness of its content: according to Blair's authoritative study of the monumental inscriptions of the eastern Islamic lands, Q. II: 127 and its proximate verses were not documented in these regions, at least through the early twelfth century, and they appeared but rarely elsewhere.[39] But the 'ulama' and other intellectuals within Mu'izz al-Din's ambit could easily find Qur'anic verses appropriate to any occasion. Given the rarity of these particular verses, it seems that they were selected with specific intent. The actual message of the verse(s) is an invocation of divine blessing on a new "house," even a royal house – especially apropos here. The monument overall, then, could conceivably be proclaiming the establishment of the third Shansabani lineage and the new rule of Sultan Mu'izz al-Din throughout the Ghaznavids' erstwhile territories.

Lashkari Bazar

Very few firmly dated architectural elements – which were *not* portable, unlike coins, ceramics, and other objects – have been recovered at any of the three sites forming the subject of this chapter. One significant find was the inscriptional panel affixed to the southern façade of Lashkari Bazar's great South Palace (Château du Sud), *in situ* during the French-led excavations there in the 1960s (Figures 5.14, 5.15, 5.17): it bore the partial date of AH 55x, corresponding to the decade of 1156–1165 CE. Based on this dating, the renovations at Lashkari Bazar have been attributed primarily to the decade after 1150 CE, an attribution I propose to modify in the rest of this chapter.

Sourdel-Thomine's rigorous analyses of the architectural epigraphy and decoration at Bust and Lashkari Bazar resulted in compelling – if at times debated – conclusions.[40] Her deep knowledge of epigraphic styles and decorative iconographies, spanning virtually the entire Persianate world of the eleventh through fourteenth centuries, permitted convincing comparisons between the inscriptional and ornamental programs of Lashkari Bazar's South Palace and relevant Saljuq, Ghaznavid, and Shansabani parallels. Also taking into account the South Palace inscription's partial date of AH 55x/1156–1165 CE